

A Book for Boys and Girls

Or, Country Rhymes for Children

JOHN BUNYAN

NORTH PASS PRESS

2026

A Book for Boys and Girls
First Edition

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Contents

Publisher's Note	2
To the Reader	4
A Book for Boys and Girls	10
A Caution to Stir Up to Watch	100
Against Sin	
Appendix	106

Publisher's Note

John Bunyan's *A Book for Boys and Girls*—later popularized as *Divine Emblems*—was first published in 1686, two years before his death. For over three centuries, however, the majority of printed editions have been based on abridged or heavily edited versions that cut out significant portions of Bunyan's original poetry and his unique pedagogical framework.

This North Pass Press edition is, to our knowledge, the first new edition of the original text since 1686. Unlike the more common *Divine Emblems* editions, which contain only 49 of the original 74 poems, this volume preserves every verse of Bunyan's "homely rhymes." Furthermore, we have included Bunyan's powerful poem, "A Caution to Stir Up to Watch Against Sin," which provides a striking detection of the "devil's sophistry" and serves as a vital companion to the emblems found within. By returning to the source text, we allow the reader to experience the full scope of Bunyan's vision—one that is as much a manual for literacy as it is a treasury of spiritual emblems.

A centerpiece of this restoration is the inclusion of the "Appendix," which Bunyan designed as "An help to Children to learn to read English." By preserving the historic alphabets and font classifications exactly as they

appeared in 1686, we invite the reader to experience the book as it was first intended: a comprehensive primer for the young and the “childish” alike.

Our edition has been carefully updated for modern readers by standardizing archaic spelling and correcting obvious historical typographic errors. However, to preserve the rhythmic pacing and distinctive character of Bunyan’s poetry, we have strictly retained the original 17th-century punctuation and syntax. Not a single word of the text has been altered or abridged; it has simply been made clean and accessible for today’s audience.

We commend this edition to the attention of all - whether a literal child or a ‘bearded boy’ - who love the unadulterated words of those who walked in the old paths.

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To the Reader

Courteous Reader,
The title-page will shew, if there thou look,
Who are the proper subjects of this book.
They're boys and girls of all sorts and degrees,
From those of age, to children on the knees.
Thus comprehensive am I in my notions;
They tempt me to it by their childish motions.
We now have boys with beards, and girls that be
Big as old women, wanting gravity.

Then do not blame me, 'cause I thus describe them;
Flatter I may not, lest thereby I bribe them
To have a better judgment of themselves,
Then wise men have of babies on their shelves.
Their antick tricks, fantastick modes, and way,
Shew they like very boys and girls, do play
With all the frantick fopp'ries of this age;
And that in open view, as on a stage;
Our *bearded* men, do act like *beardless* boys;
Our women please themselves with childish toys.

Our ministers, long time by word and pen,
Deal with them, counting them, not boys but men:
Thunder-bolts they shot at them, and their toys:

But hit then not, 'cause they were girls and boys.
The better charge, the wider still they shot,
Or else so high, these dwarfs they touched not.
Instead of men, they found them girls and boys,
Addict to nothing as to childish toys.

Wherefore good Reader, that I save them may,
I now with them, the very *dottril* play.¹
And since at gravity they make a tush,
My very beard I cast behind the bush.
And like a fool stand fing'ring of their toys;
And all to shew them, they are girls and boys.

Nor do I blush, although I think some may
Call me a baby, 'cause I with them play:
I do't to shew them how each *fingle-fangle*,
On which they doting are, their souls entangle,
As with a web, a trap, a gin, a snare:
And will destroy them, have they not a care.

Paul seemed to play the fool, that he might gain
Those that were fools indeed, if not in grain.
And did it by their things, that they might know
Their emptiness, and might be brought unto
What would them save from sin and vanity.
A noble act, and full of honesty.

¹Dottril: term used for those who imitate or are easily fooled.

Yet he nor I would like them be in vice,
While by their *play-things*, I would them entice,
To mount their thoughts from what are childish toys,
To Heav'n, for that's prepared for girls and boys.
Nor do I so confine myself to these,
As to shun graver things, I seek to please,
Those more composed with better things than toys:
Though thus I would be catching girls and boys.

Wherefore if men have now a mind to look;
Perhaps their greater fancies may be took
With what is here; though but in homely rhimes:
But he, who pleases all, must rise betimes.
Some, I persuade me, will be finding fault,
Concluding, here I trip, and there I halt,
No doubt some could these groveling notions raise
By fine-spun terms that challenge might the bays.²
But should all men be forc't to lay aside
Their brains, that cannot regulate the tide:
By this or that man's fancy, we should have
The wise, unto the fool, become a slave.
What though my text seems mean, my morals be
Grave, as if fetcht from a sublimer tree.
And if some better handle can a fly,

²The bays: A reference to the laurel wreath (bay leaves) traditionally worn by poets and conquerors as a symbol of honor and literary achievement.

Then some a text, why should we them deny
Their making proof, or good experiment,
Of smallest things great mischiefs to prevent?

Wise Solomon did fools to piss-ants³ send,
To learn true wisdom, and their lives to mend.
Yea, God by swallows, cuckows, and the ass;
Shews they are fools who let that season pass,
Which he put in their hand, that to obtain
Which is both present, and eternal gain.

I think the wiser sort my rhimes may slight
But what were I! The foolish will delight
To read them, and the foolish, God has chose.
And doth by foolish things, their minds compose,
And settle upon that which is divine:
Great things, by little ones, are made to shine.

I could, were I so pleased, use higher strains.
And for applause, on tenters stretch my brains,
But what needs that? The arrow out of sight,
Does not the sleeper, nor the watchman fright.
To shoot too high doth but make children gaze;
'Tis that which hits the man, doth him amaze.

³Piss-ants: An archaic term for common wood ants (also called pismires), named for the sharp, pungent scent of formic acid they produce.

And for the inconsiderableness
Of things, by which I do my mind express;
May I by them bring some good thing to pass,
As Sampson, with the jaw-bone of an ass;
Or as brave Shamgar with his ox's goad,
(Both things not manly, nor for war in mode)
I have my end, though I myself expose
To scorn; God will have glory in the close.

Thus much for artificial babes; and now
To those who are in years but such, I bow
My pen to teach them what the letters be,
And how they may improve their A, B, C.
Nor let my pretty children them despise;
All needs must there begin, that would be wise.

Nor let *them* fall under discouragement,
Who at their hornbook stick,⁴ and time hath spent
Upon that A, B, C while others do
Into their primer, or their Psalter go.
Some boys with difficulty do begin,
Who in the end, the bays, and laurel win.

– J. B.

⁴Hornbook stick: A primary educational tool consisting of a wooden paddle covered by a translucent sheet of animal horn to protect the printed lesson. It represents the most basic level of instruction.

A Book for Boys and Girls

I

Upon the Ten Commandments

1. Thou shalt not have another God than me:
2. Thou shalt not to an image bow thy knee,
3. Thou shalt not take the Name of God in vain:
4. See that the Sabbath thou do not profain.
5. Honour thy father and thy mother too:
6. In act or thought see thou no murder do.
7. From fornication keep thy body clean:
8. Thou shalt not steal, though thou be very mean.⁵
9. Bear no false witness, keep thee without spot:
10. What is thy neighbour's see thou covet not.

II

The Awakened Child's Lamentation

When Adam was deceived,
I was of Life bereaved;

⁵Mean: Poor or impoverished.

Of late (too) I perceived,
I was in sin conceived.

And as I was born naked,
I was with filth bespaked,
At which when I awaked,
My soul and spirit shaken.

My filth grew strong, and boyled,
And me throughout defiled,
My pleasures me beguiled,
My soul! how art thou spoyled!

My joys with sin were painted,
My mind with sin is tainted,
My heart with guilt is fainted,
I wa'nt⁶ with God acquainted.

I have in sin abounded,
My heart therewith is wounded,
With fears I am surrounded,
My spirit is confounded.

I have been often called,
By sin as oft enthralled,
Pleasures hath me fore-stalled.
How is my spirit gauled!

⁶wasn't

As sin has me infected,
I am thereof detected:
Mercy I have neglected,
I fear I am rejected.

The Word I have mis-used
Good council too refused;
Thus I myself abused;
How can I be excused?

When other children prayed,
That work I then delayed,
Ran up and down and played;
And thus from God have strayed.

Had I in God delighted,
And my wrong doings righted;
I had not thus been frightened,
Nor as I am benighted.

O! That God would be pleased,
T'wards me to be appeased;
And heal me thus diseased,
How should I then be eased!

But Truth I have despised,
My follies idolized,

Saints with reproach disguised,
Salvation nothing prized.

O Lord! I am ashamed,
When I do hear thee named;
'Cause thee I have defamed,
And liv'd like beasts untamed!

Would God I might be saved,
Might have an heart like David;
This I have sometimes craved,
Yet am by sin enslaved!

Vanity I have loved,
My heart from God removed;
And not, as me behoved,
The means of grace improved.

O Lord! if I had cried
(When I told tales and lyed)
For mercy, and denied
My lusts, I had not died!

But Mercies-Gate is locked,
Yea, up that way is blocked;
Yea some that there have knocked,
God at their cries hath mocked.

'Cause him they had disdained,
Their wicked ways maintained,
From godliness restrained,
And on his word complained.

I would I were converted
Would sin and I were parted,
For folly I have smarted;
God make me honest-hearted!

I have to grace appealed,
Would 'twere to me revealed,
And pardon to me sealed,
Then should I soon be healed!

Whose nature God hath mended,
Whose sinful course is ended,
Who is to life ascended,
Of God is much befriended.

Oh! Were I reconciled
To God, I, though defiled,
Should be as one that smiled,
To think my death was spoiled.

Lord! thou wast crucified
For sinners, bled and dyed,

I have for mercy cried,
Let me not be denyed.

I have thy Spirit grieved;
Yet is my life reprieved,
Would I in thee believed,
Then I should be relieved.

Were but repentance gained,
And had I faith unfeigned,
Then joy would be maintained
In me, and sin restrained.

But this is to be noted,
I have on folly doted,
My vanities promoted,
Myself to them devoted.

Thus I have sin committed,
And so myself out-witted;
Yea, and my soul unfitted,
To be to Heaven admitted.

But God has condescended,
And pardon has extended,
To such as have offended,
Before their lives were ended.

O Lord! do not disdain me,
But kindly entertain me;
Yea in thy faith maintain me,
And let thy love constrain me!

III

Meditations Upon An Egg

The egg's no chick by falling from the hen;
Nor man a Christian, till he's born agen.
The egg's at first contained in the shell;
Men afore grace, in sins, and darkness dwell.
The egg when laid, by warmth is made a chicken;
And Christ, by grace, those dead in sin doth
quicken.
The egg, when first a chick, the shell's its prison;
So's flesh to th'soul, who yet with Christ is risen.
The shell doth crack, the chick doth chirp and peep;
The flesh decays, as men do pray and weep.
The shell doth break, the chick's at liberty;
The flesh falls off, the soul mounts up on high.
But both do not enjoy the self-same plight;
The soul is safe, the chick now fears the kite.⁷

⁷Kite: A bird of prey.